

HRM6070 Paper #2

Amanda Tremblay at Citrine Software Solutions: A Case Analysis

Tejasvini Kameswaran

Introduction

The case of Amanda Tremblay at Citrine Software Solutions (CSS) presents a multifaceted scenario of international human resource management (IHRM), expatriate adjustment, cultural intelligence, leadership development, and global talent strategy. Amanda, a high-performing manager at CSS, was appointed General Manager (GM) of the Vietnam subsidiary despite limited international experience. Her assignment, framed as a strategic opportunity to establish a strong company presence in Southeast Asia, rapidly evolves into a test of cross-cultural competence, ethical judgment, and HR decision-making. This paper addresses five key questions from the case and evaluates Amanda's role, challenges, and decisions using IHRM principles, course concepts, and secondary literature. The primary reference is Tarique, Briscoe, and Schuler (2022), whose frameworks guide this analysis.

1. Was Amanda Tremblay the right choice as general manager of CSS's Vietnam subsidiary? Why or why not? How does this relate to the selection/evaluation process that a company may use to identify and prepare a candidate for an international assignment?

Amanda Tremblay, though clearly a high performer at CSS, was ultimately not the optimal choice for the GM position in Vietnam. From the perspective of expatriate selection criteria outlined by Tarique et al. (2022), her appointment lacked alignment with key success factors such as cultural adaptability, prior international exposure, and contextual intelligence. Her technical and leadership abilities in the Canadian office were not, by themselves, sufficient predictors of success in a culturally distinct environment like Vietnam. According to the textbook, a structured expatriate selection process should consider multiple predictors of international assignment success, including personality traits (e.g., openness, tolerance for

ambiguity), relational skills, language proficiency, and intercultural competence (Tarique et al., 2022, p. 262).

Amanda was appointed more for her past domestic achievements and less for her potential to navigate global-local dynamics. This approach reflects a common misstep identified by Bielinska (2024), who argues that leaders must be selected not only for their business acumen but also for their ability to balance global strategy with local sensitivities. Amanda's initial culture shock, strained communication with Vietnamese staff, and rigid leadership style indicate a lack of preparation for these dynamics.

The strategic misfit is further evident in the absence of formal cross-cultural training and mentoring, two elements emphasized by Vaiman, Van Bakel, and Vance (2022) as essential for expatriate success. Without these supports, Amanda's transition became more reactive than strategic. Therefore, while Amanda was a competent manager, she was not the right candidate for this specific international role, especially without structured support and pre-departure preparation.

2. As Mark Feinsted, how would you evaluate Tremblay's performance to date? Please provide specifics regarding major accomplishments/challenges she has faced, and how she has performed against key performance criteria. What coaching would you provide?

From the perspective of Mark Feinsted, Amanda Tremblay's performance has been mixed—marked by operational improvements and personal resilience, but also by substantial relational and strategic missteps. To evaluate her performance, we should use the expatriate performance criteria outlined in the course textbook: task performance, contextual performance (including cultural adaptability), and assignment-specific objectives (Tarique et al., 2022).

Task-wise, Amanda has succeeded in certain core managerial functions. She has improved internal processes, pushed forward initiatives to professionalize the operation, and brought a much-needed focus on quality control. These efforts are commendable and align with the performance metric of contributing to the strategic goals of the subsidiary. Her ability to withstand pressure, remain ethical amidst political complexity, and remain committed to the company despite numerous challenges suggests high levels of psychological capital—a concept supported by the psychology literature that underscores resilience and self-efficacy as essential to leadership endurance (Luthans & Youssef-Morgan, 2017).

However, Amanda has faltered in contextual performance. One of the most pressing concerns is her inability to build trust with her Vietnamese team, especially with Duc. She entered the role with a task-oriented mindset, which alienated her from the socio-relational work culture of Vietnam. According to Hofstede’s cultural dimensions, Vietnam scores high on power distance and collectivism—cultures in which hierarchy and relationships matter deeply. Amanda’s directness and failure to navigate implicit communication norms likely contributed to a lack of team cohesion (Tarique et al., 2022).

Her relationship with Duc, a politically astute and experienced local executive, further exposes a gap in her cross-cultural leadership capabilities. Rather than leveraging Duc as a cultural bridge, Amanda perceived him as a threat, which is a classic expatriate failure point identified in international assignments (Tarique et al., 2022). This misalignment has contributed to organizational friction and may even risk key talent attrition.

As her supervisor, Mark should focus his coaching on several fronts:

- **Cultural Intelligence (CQ) Development:** Amanda needs active support in developing cultural intelligence, particularly meta-cognitive and behavioral CQ. Training that combines role-playing, scenario simulation, and reflective practice could support this growth (Tarique et al., 2022).

- **Relationship-Building:** She should be coached on the importance of guanxi-style networking in Asian cultures. The Deloitte (2024) survey highlights that leadership success increasingly depends on emotional and social intelligence, not just strategic execution.
- **Mentorship and Peer Networks:** Amanda would benefit from a mentor who has led international assignments in emerging markets. Vaiman et al. (2022) emphasize mentorship as a linchpin of expatriate adjustment, performance, and retention.
- **Strategic Delegation and Political Acumen:** Amanda needs to be coached on how to delegate more effectively and collaborate with political stakeholders such as Duc, rather than viewing him as opposition.

In conclusion, Amanda has shown grit and drive, but her effectiveness remains hampered by a lack of global leadership acumen. With the right coaching interventions—grounded in cultural awareness and relational intelligence—she can still succeed in this role.

3. Should Tremblay approve Duc's contract proposal? Why or why not?

Amanda should not approve Duc's contract proposal in its current form, primarily due to ethical, organizational justice, and HR consistency concerns. Duc's demand for a sizable salary increase and added privileges, justified by his client relationships, presents a form of opportunistic negotiation that could destabilize team morale and set a dangerous precedent. Tarique et al. (2022) emphasize the importance of procedural and distributive justice in international HRM decisions (p. 205). If Amanda approves this deal, she risks signaling that negotiation leverage trumps over performance-based rewards and standardized compensation structures. This move may encourage others to threaten resignation to obtain personal benefits, undermining trust and fairness within the team.

That said, Duc is a high-performing employee with valuable relationships. Rather than accepting or rejecting his proposal outright, Amanda should implement a structured retention and recognition strategy. She could propose a performance-linked bonus or career development opportunities, which uphold equity while acknowledging Duc's contributions. This strategy also resonates with the concept of talent segmentation, discussed by Ali (2024), who advocates for differentiated retention strategies in global mobility settings. Ultimately, Amanda's decision should reflect long-term strategic thinking about talent sustainability rather than short-term appeasement. Rejecting Duc's terms while offering a fair alternative sends a strong message about the organization's commitment to both equity and retention.

4. How should she deal with the proposed data center relocation issue?

Amanda should oppose the proposed relocation of the data center from Vietnam to Singapore. Her opposition, however, must be framed strategically rather than defensively. The proposed move, initiated by the head office, is based on a cost-benefit analysis that may undervalue the long-term implications of centralizing IT infrastructure in Singapore. Amanda must prepare a data-backed argument highlighting the subsidiary's recent progress, the impact on Vietnamese staff morale, and the strategic importance of local capability development. Tarique et al. (2022) emphasize the importance of localization strategies and empowering subsidiaries to build autonomous capacities (p. 412). Removing the data center would not only demoralize the local team but also signal a lack of trust in Amanda's leadership. Amanda can argue that retaining the data center supports CSS's global talent development strategy by building local technical expertise and leadership pipelines. Furthermore, Amanda can draw on insights from Deloitte's 2024 global talent survey, which emphasized that decisions involving talent and infrastructure must be people-centric and

future-oriented. She should recommend a joint task force to evaluate the technological, financial, and human capital implications of the move, rather than accepting a top-down mandate.

Amanda's stand, if executed with diplomacy and supported by metrics, could position her as a credible advocate for CSS Vietnam, demonstrating leadership beyond compliance and toward strategic influence.

5. What should she do about the performance problems with internal technical consultants?

Amanda must take decisive action to address the underperformance of internal technical consultants. Their poor delivery is not only damaging project timelines but also undermining her credibility with clients and partners. From a human resource management perspective, Amanda should implement a targeted performance management plan, grounded in the practices of performance appraisal and capability building (Tarique et al., 2022, p. 204). The first step involves a structured performance diagnosis to determine whether the root causes are skill deficits, motivation issues, or role misalignment. Based on this analysis, Amanda should develop individualized improvement plans that include mentoring, training modules, and clear KPIs. This aligns with the recommendation of Juliana Guaqueta Ospira (2024), who highlights the need to reskill employees for future readiness, especially in tech-driven sectors.

Simultaneously, Amanda must engage with CSS headquarters to address systemic issues—such as poor knowledge sharing and siloed teams—that are hampering cross-border collaboration. If after these interventions, consultants continue to underperform, Amanda must not shy away from recommending replacements, guided by procedural fairness and documentation.

Her approach should reflect a mix of developmental leadership and performance accountability, demonstrating that she can drive both results and people development in complex settings.

Conclusion

Amanda Tremblay's assignment at CSS Vietnam serves as a compelling case for the importance of holistic expatriate preparation, adaptive leadership, and strategic HRM in international assignments. While Amanda possesses strong managerial instincts, her effectiveness has been constrained by insufficient cultural preparation, inconsistent HR practices, and top-down pressures. By adopting a culturally intelligent, ethically grounded, and strategically assertive approach, Amanda can transform her experience into a success story—not just for herself, but for CSS's global ambitions. Drawing from the foundational principles in Tarique et al. (2022), her journey underscores that global leadership is not merely about control or delivery, but about influence, alignment, and adaptive growth.

References

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